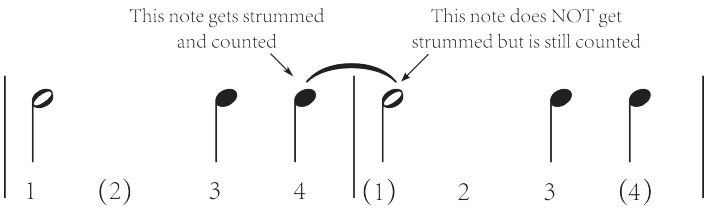
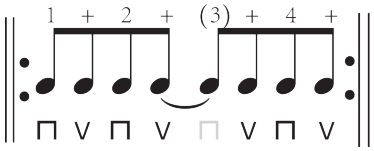
LESSON 10: TIES

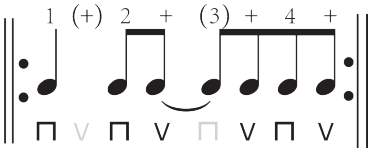
A tie is a way of adding two notes together. It will extend the duration of the first note, causing it to sustain past the note it is tied to. The first note is played — the second one is not (but is still counted).

In this example, we see that the "4 beat" in the first measure (that's the last quarter note in measure 1) is tied to the "1 beat" of the next measure. This means our "4 beat" *will* be played/strummed, *but* will sustain-for a value of three counts, and we won't strum the upcoming 1 beat.



In these next examples, an eighth note is tied to another eighth note, creating a note that rings out for a full beat.

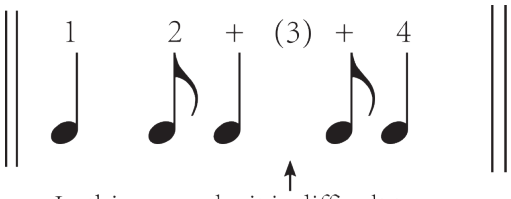




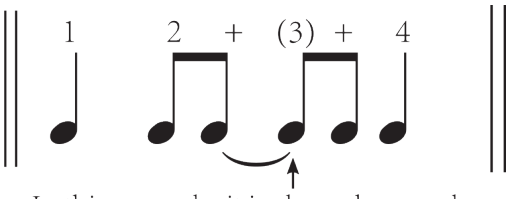
Why Use Musical Ties?

It is helpful to easily identify the halfway point of a measure at a glance. By using ties, we can preserve the symmetry of our measures and make it easier to see where our 3 beat occurs.

The two rhythms below are the same, but could be written with or without ties. Which is easier for your eyes to read and interpret?



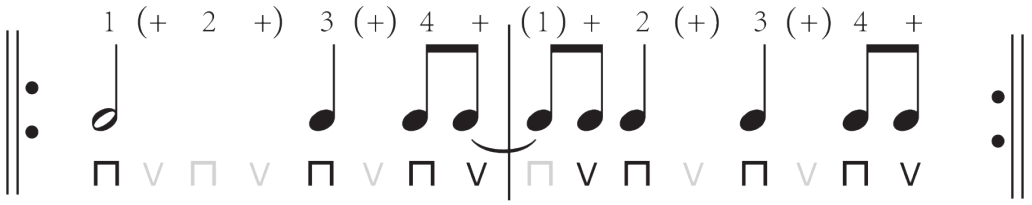
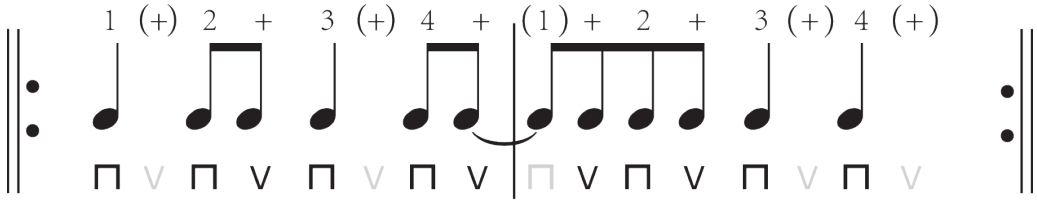
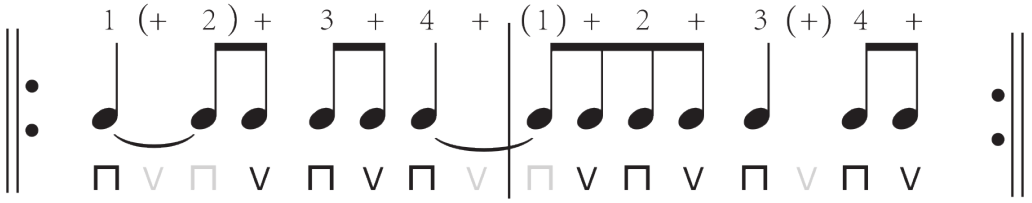
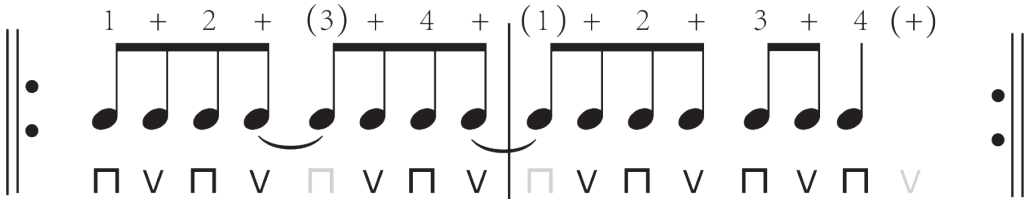
In this example, it is difficult to see exactly where the 3 beat is.



In this example, it is clear where each down beat begins.

Ties are also used when a note must ring out past the end of the measure, as seen in the example at the top of this page.

Exercises (Video #10.1)

Practice each of these two-measure rhythms on a loop, using any open chord of your choice. Tap your foot, and count the strums out loud. On the “missed” strums, say those counts quietly.

Ensure that your hand is still moving up and down at all times!